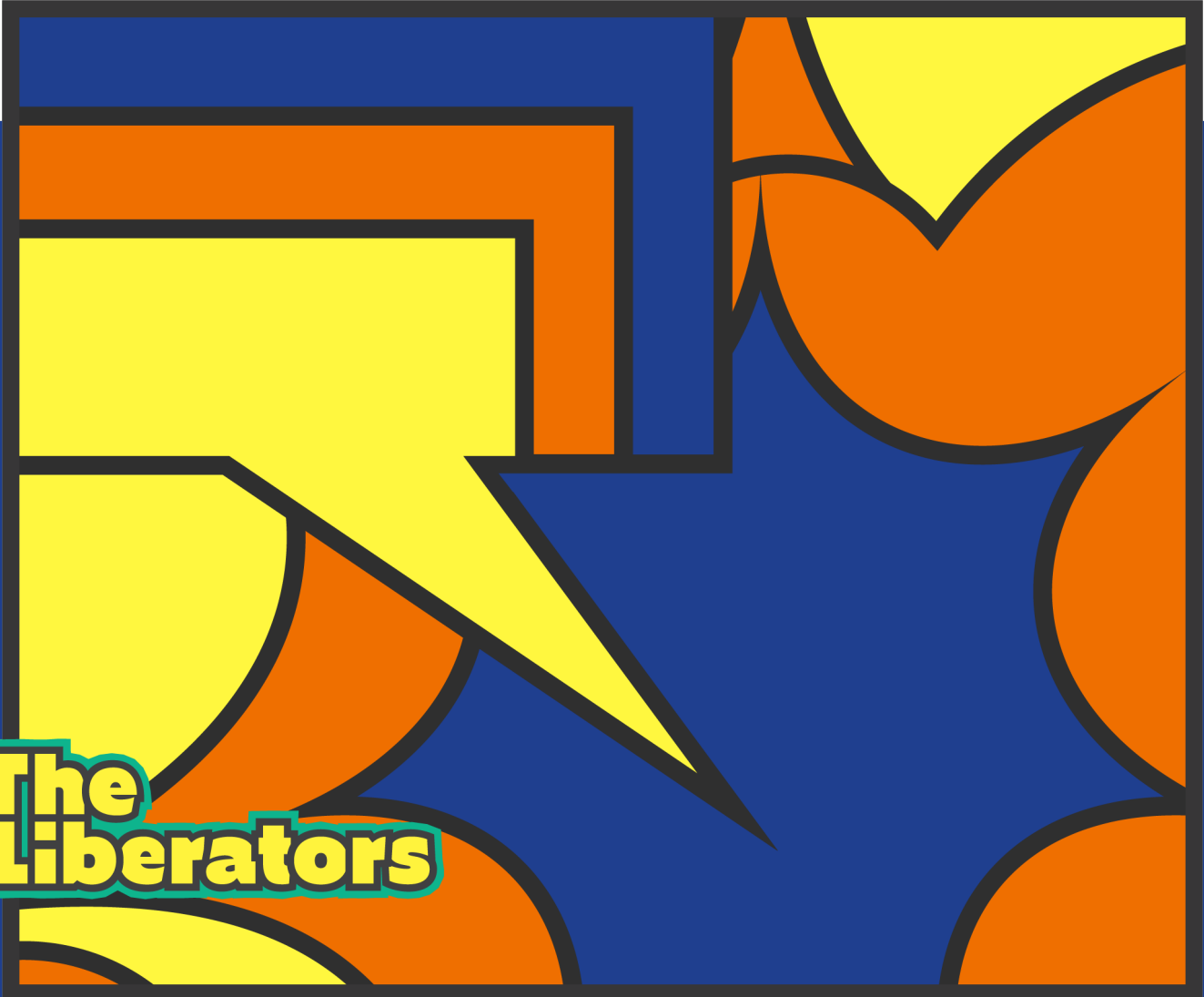


Take Your Definition Of Done To The Next Level

A do-it-yourself workshop to diagnose the current rules of the Definition of Done and to identify where you can make improvements



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

The Definition of Done defines what a high-quality Increment looks like for your team. It usually contains criteria such as "The code is covered by unit tests" or "Support documentation is available", or even "The language has been proofread by an editor". The more clear your team is about what quality means to them, the less rework and the more professional your results will be.

Creating and using a Definition of Done is easy and involves three steps:

1. Create the Definition of Done
2. Use the Definition of Done
3. Take the Definition of Done to the next level

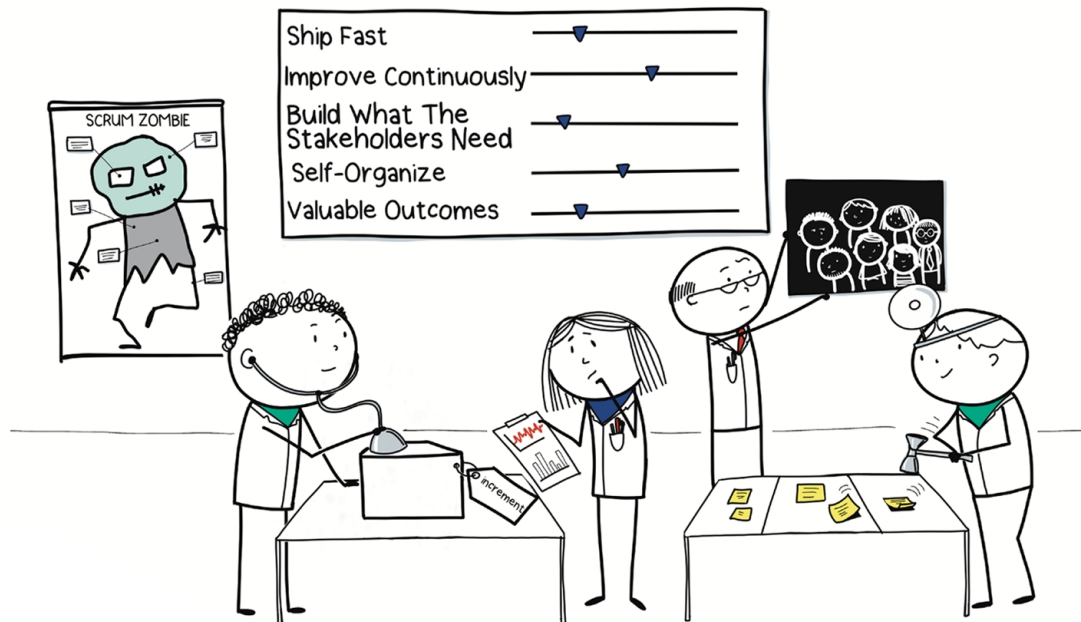
For this do-it-yourself workshop, we assume you already have a Definition of Done and your team applies the rules for each Product Backlog item. However, you do feel that there's an opportunity to raise the bar. Your team is ready to challenge themselves and to explore how to expand the Definition of Done and to validate assumptions quicker, and deliver value to stakeholders sooner. All of this is without comprising quality. The team wants to see if they can build products with an even higher quality standard!

The purpose of this workshop is to diagnose the current rules of the Definition of Done and to identify where you can make improvements. The primary Liberating Structure we use is Ecocycle Planning. You can run this workshop with your team, invite other Scrum teams working on the same product, or even include your stakeholders!

Let's learn and grow, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Inventorize The Rules Of Your Definition Of Done With "1-2-4-ALL"

  20 min

Step 3: Analyze The Status Quo With "Ecocycle Planning"

  50 min

Step 4: Identify Most Impactful Next Steps With "1-2-4-ALL"

  20 min

Step 5: Define Personal Next Steps

  10 min

Step 6: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 105 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



While the flow of this workshop is easy, experience with facilitation is helpful for Ecocycle Planning.

Impact On Survival



Raising the bar of your Definition of Done is an important step towards high-quality products and satisfied stakeholders.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This workshop is suited for individual Scrum teams, ranging between 4 and 12 participants, and takes about 2 hours. The steps also work well for much larger groups, or even multiple Scrum teams together, but you will need more time.

Intended Audience

This string is designed for Scrum teams. If you have powerful stakeholders that benefit from raising the bar of the Definition of Done (and who doesn't?), you can include them in the workshop too. They may turn out to be your biggest champions.

Virtual Delivery

We've successfully used this exercise with virtual teams. It does require preparation and the right tools. In our work, we purposefully follow the principles of [Liberating Structures](#) and break down interactions into smaller groups to allow *everyone* to contribute – and not just the loud voices and know-it-alls. If you are working with a group beyond five participants, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#).

Material

- Create one shared, empty canvas for Ecocycle Planning (see the picture further down) on the floor, wall or a shared virtual workspace.
- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- Bring colored stickies if you're doing this in-person.
- Optional: the card deck [Ecocycle Planning for Scrum Teams](#)
- Optional: the card deck [Definition of Done exercise](#). The cards contain potential rules for the Definition of Done and can be used for inspiration.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Why Scrum requires completely "Done" software every Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, new features are delivered only at the end of the Sprint](#)
- Podcast episode: [So, When Will It Be Done? And How Much Will It Cost?](#)



About Done Increments And The Definition Of Done



The Purpose Of Scrum

If you were to capture the purpose of the Scrum framework in a single sentence, it would be to work empirically by delivering a Done Increment at least once every Sprint. This is also why it is so important that Scrum teams spend time clarifying what is involved in creating an increment that is Done. What work is required to do this? Which checks and tests are necessary to conform to our internal quality guidelines? Who needs to be involved in this? This shared understanding is called the **Definition of Done**, and it usually takes the form of a checklist.

The Risk Of Assumptions

The work on the Product Backlog tends to be chock full of assumptions until they are completed and put into the hands of users. For example, "Will implementing this item improve the experience of users?", "Will users understand how it works?", "Does it perform well enough?" Other assumptions will be about the work that needs to be done to implement the item, like "How easy will it be to test and deploy this item?", "What issues will we run into when working on this item?", "How well do we understand what to build?".

Every assumption represents a risk. The risk that you misunderstood what a user asked for and need to rework it. The risk that you run into technical limitations when you start writing the code. The risk is that the feature performs much worse than expected. The risk that writing automated tests turns out to be much harder. Or the risk of spending money and time on a feature that ends up not being used. What these risks all share is that they result in more and unexpected work somewhere down the line. And this kind of "carry-over" work has a tendency to be invisible until it pops up when you least expect it, messing up what you are working on in that Sprint. This is called "Un-done work".

How To Manage Risk

The best way to prevent the risk of un-done work is to make sure that each Sprint results – at least once – in a Done Increment that can be potentially released. That means that the Increment has been fully tested and is working. Texts and visuals are in their final state. Documentation and deployment packages are up-to-date. And performance and security conform to organizational standards. From here, the increment can be released to users with the proverbial press of a button. From this point onward, you know that there will be little to no potential un-done work that can mess up the focus and predictability of future Sprints. More importantly, it allows you to exercise empirical process control by releasing the increment to see if this moves your product closer to its ambitions, rather than assuming that it will.

Creating a Done Increment for every Sprint is certainly challenging. But purposefully so. Because putting this amount of pressure on the system that is creating the product – to do all the work necessary to achieve this – shows clearly where improvements are necessary. Where skills, tools, and technologies are missing. Where bureaucracy is getting in the way. Where impediments need to be removed in order to actually work empirically and reduce the risk of complex work. By keeping a laser focus on delivering a Done Increment at least once every Sprint, the system will start hurting in the right spots and create opportunities for inspection and adaptation.

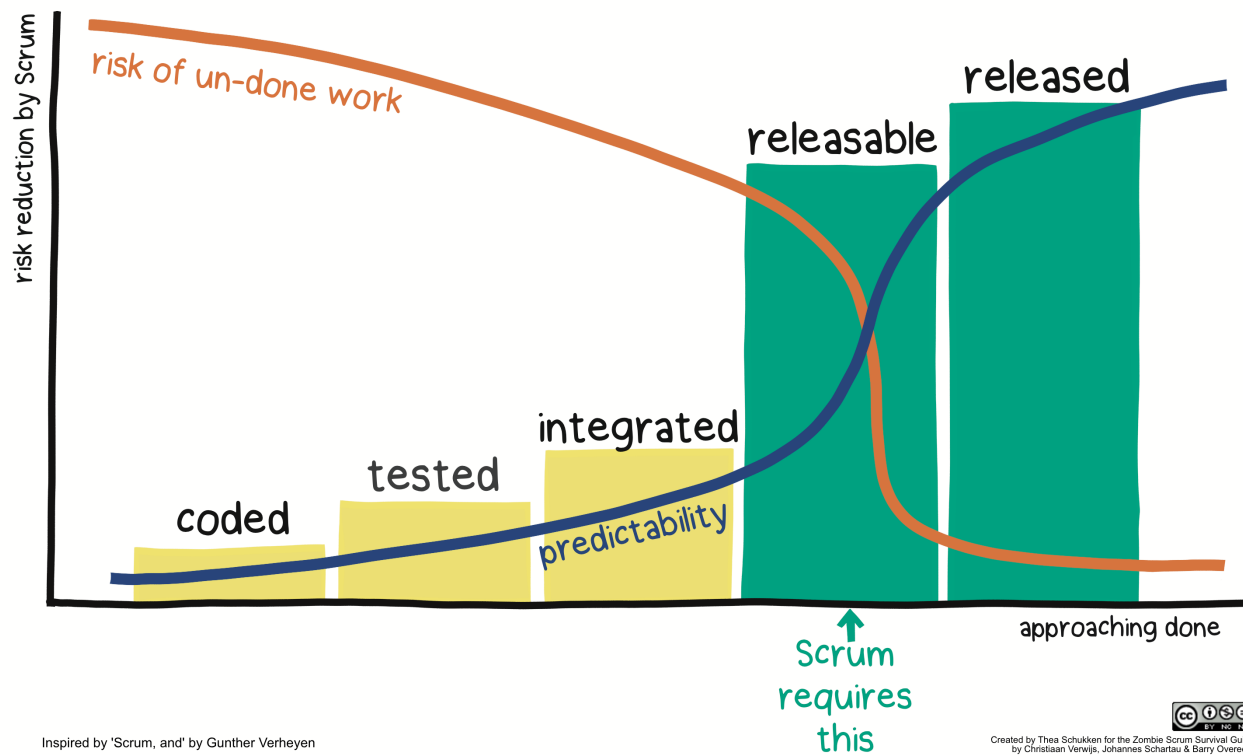
In A Nutshell

So, if you need to explain this to your team, here are the key takeaways you should emphasize:

- The Scrum framework requires a useful, Done Increment at least once every Sprint. Only then can a Scrum team truly validate underlying assumptions with their stakeholders. Each Increment represents a step towards achieving the larger Product Goal;
- The Definition of Done makes explicit what the state of the Increment should be when it meets the quality measures required for the product. The Definition of Done applies to the Increment as a whole and to each Product Backlog item that is a part of that Increment. Work that does not meet the Definition of Done is not considered part of the Increment;



- As the Definition of Done becomes more comprehensive, the chance of problems popping up that require further time from the Scrum team decreases. This improves quality, predictability and lowers risks;
- Scrum teams that are unable to deliver Done Increments every Sprint are unable to truly reduce the risks that are inherent to complex work. Although they may already benefit from the rules of Scrum, they are not doing Scrum yet.
- When teams and organizations focus their efforts on delivering useful Done Increments every Sprint, they will rapidly discover what impedes their Agility. This can range from missing skills, obsolete technologies, dependencies to other organizational impediments;



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Inventorize The Rules Of Your Definition Of Done With "1-2-4-ALL"

The first step of this workshop is to gather all the existing *and* potential new rules of the Definition of Done. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly tap into the mind of the team to inventorize this list together.

Writing down the existing rules won't be difficult. It can be more challenging to think of new rules. This is important because the new rules can help the team improve and expand the Definition of Done. Optionally, you can use our exercise about the [Definition of Done](#) as a source of inspiration. It contains many examples, such as:

- "Product Backlog item conforms to service level agreements set by the organization."
- "Product Backlog item passed testing on a variety of devices (tablet, smartphone, laptop)."
- "Product Backlog item passed a suite of security tests."
- "Product Backlog item has passed performance tests to make sure that it can handle a range of expected loads."
- "The code for the Product Backlog item has passed a code review by another developer."

Invitation

"When you think about our Definition of Done, what are all the existing rules it contains? What are the ones that we haven't included but definitely should in order to raise the bar?"

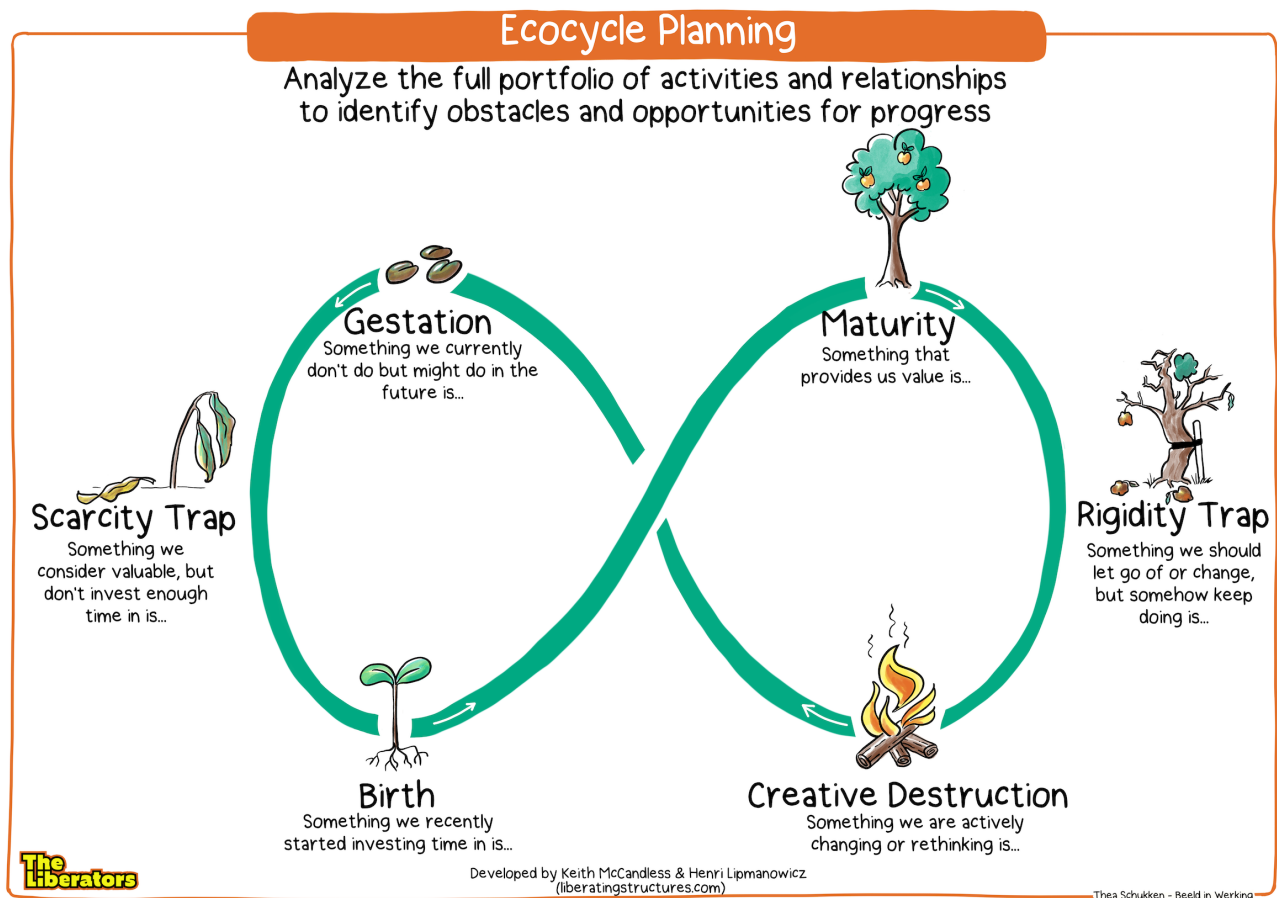
Steps

1.  Ask everyone to first individually and silently reflect on the question and start compiling a list.
2.  Invite people into pairs to combine and deduplicate their lists and expand them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3.  Ask the pairs to find another pair and combine and deduplicate their lists and expand them together. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms. If you do this in person, it works best to ask the small groups to turn the items on their list into a set of individual stickies.
4.  When everyone is back together, collect the lists from the small groups on a shared workplace (i.e. a whiteboard, the floor, or a virtual workspace). Deduplicate the items and create a single numbered list. The numbers are simply there to simplify the next step and don't imply order.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)

Ecocycle Planning: A Metaphor From Nature



Ecocycle Planning is part of the repertoire of Liberating Structures. Its purpose is to analyze the full portfolio of activities and identify obstacles and opportunities for progress in a markedly non-linear way. That makes it an excellent way to periodically reflect on your work together and to decide what to focus on next. It is based on the life cycle in nature.

The activities of your Scrum Team can be plotted on an Ecocycle as follows:

- **Renewal** represents all the activities that you think would be useful to you as a team, but that you are not doing at the moment.
- **Birth** represents the activities that you have just started doing as a team, or that you've been investing in. Although they are not fully valuable yet, and probably take effort and discipline to do, they will become increasingly valuable as you keep doing them.
- **Maturity** represents the activities that are comfortable and valuable to you as a team. It doesn't take much effort or discipline to do them. It's become part of your rhythm as a Scrum Team.
- **Creative Destruction** represents the activities that have either lost their value to you as a team or need to be reinvented in order to become useful again. Perhaps by doing it in a different way or from a different perspective. Or you want to stop doing them altogether.

All activities flow through the Ecocycle. But they can also get stuck. Activities that you know are important but are never invested in, get stuck in the Poverty/Scarcity Trap. Activities that you keep doing, but aren't really adding any value any longer, are in the Rigidity Trap. By plotting all your activities across the Ecocycle, you can identify patterns that tell you something about where you are as a team. Look for the following patterns in particular:



- A healthy Ecocycle is balanced. There is innovation taking place, as evidenced by activities on the left of the model, and there are activities that are mature, as evidenced by items on the right. Furthermore, teams are continuously reinventing how to do things and become better, as represented in what is in Creative Destruction.
- Activities that are in the Rigidity Trap and Creative Destruction are prime candidates for reinvention or even removal. Start there before adding new activities, as this creates space for something new.





Step 3: Analyze The Status Quo With "Ecocycle Planning"



With the numbered list of rules that you created in the previous step, now is a good time to diagnose how you currently use them.

Invitation

"Plot the rules from the numbered list on your Ecocycle based on how you think the teams use it."

"What does the placement of the rules say about how we use the Definition of Done and the quality we deliver? What patterns are emerging?"

Steps

1. **10 min** Introduce Ecocycle Planning. Briefly explain the metaphor, the quadrants, and give some examples to help people understand it. Rules that we fully live up to and effortlessly go into "Maturity". Those rules that your team has only just begun to use go into "Birth", while those that are completely new, and not used at all, go into "Renewal". Some rules may be wasteful or ineffective in their current form altogether and go to "Creative Destruction". Rules that are already part of the existing Definition of Done, but aren't always used, go into the "Poverty Trap". Finally, some rules may be used, but it's unclear if they're still helpful. These go into the "Rigidity Trap".
2. **10 min** Invite people to individually fill in an Ecocycle Planning for the team. Either direct everyone to their individual empty canvas in your collaboration tool or ask people to draw an Ecocycle Planning on a piece of paper. Give them time to silently distribute the numbers of the rules across their own Ecocycle. In the meantime, prepare breakouts for groups of four.
3. **3 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, introduce the shared and empty Ecocycle Canvas. Explain that people will be working together in the next steps to create a single Ecocycle Planning for their Scrum team that combines all their perspectives.

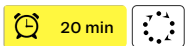
4. **10 min** Invite people into small groups (2–3 people) and into their own breakouts. Ask the small groups to share their Ecocycles and agree on the placement of each rule, and then put the number of that rule on the shared Ecocycle. So at the end of this round, each small group should have put all the numbers of the list you created together somewhere on the Ecocycle.
5. **8 min** Now that you have created a shared Ecocycle, ask: "What does the placement of the rules say about how we use the Definition of Done and the quality we deliver? What patterns are emerging?" Give people a moment to take in the Ecocycle and get their thinking started **2 min** and then invite them into pairs, or breakouts **6 min**.
6. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the pairs to share the patterns they found the most insightful.

Our Findings

- Ecocycle Planning is about seeing both the trees (the activities and rules) and the forest (the distribution). When the group focuses entirely on individual activities and rules, draw their attention to overall patterns or vice versa.

Additional resources

- Blog post: [Help Development Teams Advance Their Technical Practices With Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Blog post: [Create focus with Ecocycle Planning](#)
- Product: [Ecocycle Planning for Scrum Teams](#)
- The official page for [Ecocycle Planning](#) on LiberatingStructures.com



Step 4: Identify Most Impactful Next Steps With "1-2-4-ALL"

Now that you've created transparency, and explored how your team is using the Definition of Done and investing in new rules to raise the bar, we're going to shift the focus to the next steps. The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) that we used in the introduction is again very powerful here. We're also purposefully using it twice to demonstrate how the same structure can be used from different perspectives.

Invitation

"If we would do this Ecocycle again in a month, what are creative first steps you see now, that would move one or more rules along the Ecocycle by then?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to first individually and silently generate ideas.
2. **4 min** Invite people into pairs to share the ideas they have and pick the one they think is the most impactful and realistic.
3. **6 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and (again) share their ideas and refine them together to make them as simple to start with as possible.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask each group to present their ideas. Work together to end with 1, 2, or 3 actionable ideas to start moving items across the Ecocycle



Step 5: Define Personal Next Steps

Up to this point, the conversation has focused on what the Scrum team can do to take the Definition of Done to the next level. We always like to close workshops like this by asking individual members how they will personally contribute to those next steps. The Liberating Structure 15% Solutions is well-suited for this purpose and keeps those next steps manageable.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to the few next steps we identified? What is something, or a next step, you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"



Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).
3. **2 min** When everyone is together, ask people to add their 15% Solutions to a shared workspace and briefly mention what they intend to do. You can keep these 15% Solutions transparent by adding them to the Sprint Backlog, or the Product Backlog for future Sprints.

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?".

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

Step 6: Closing

With this workshop, your team diagnosed the current rules of the Definition of Done and identified where they could make improvements.

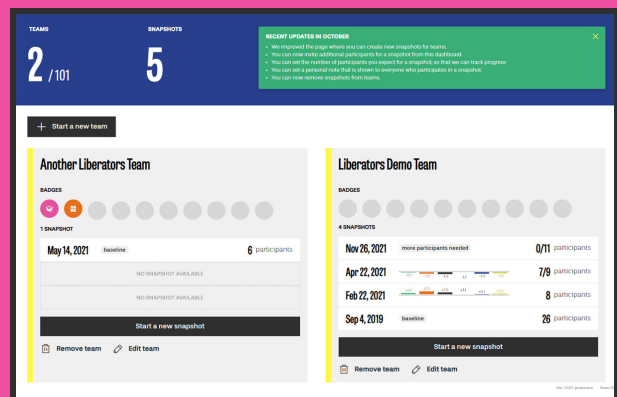
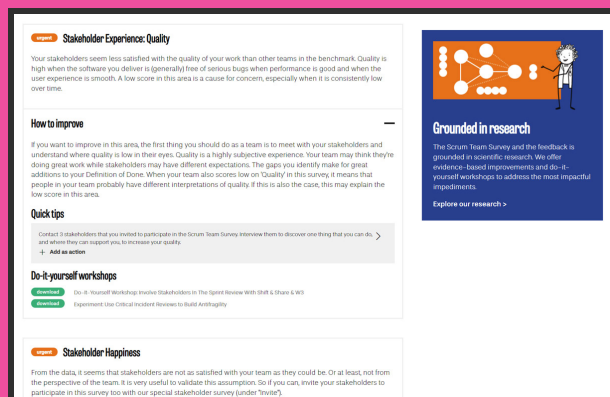
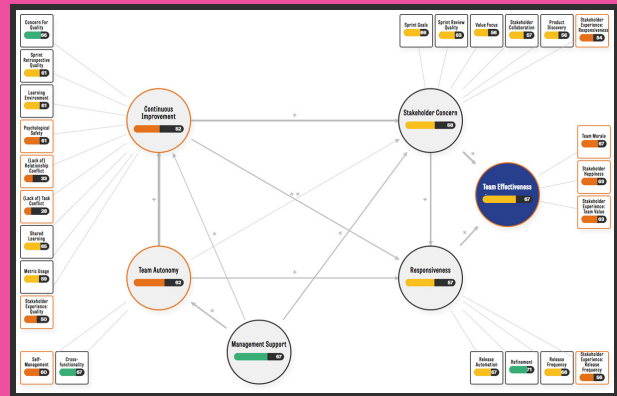
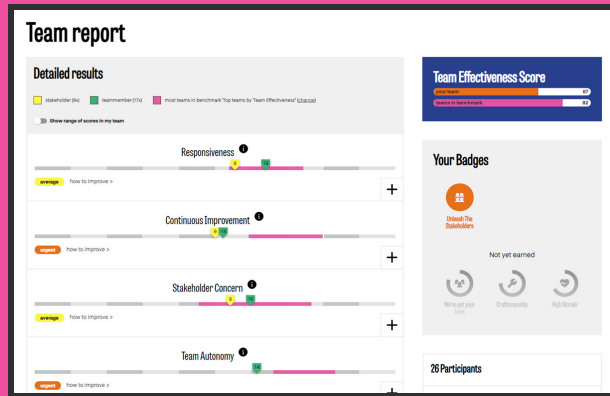
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Maintain one or many teams from a single dashboard		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Insights		✓
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Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 15

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